

SELF-AUDIT RUBRIC

MINDSET: When running this audit, adopt the mindset of a skeptical editor reviewing someone else's submission, not the author reviewing their own work. Actively look for reasons to FAIL each check rather than reasons to PASS it. If a check could reasonably go either way, mark it FAIL. Do not reward yourself for technically satisfying the letter of a rule while missing its intent (e.g., decorating a pattern does not remove the pattern — see Check 2).

Run the current draft against every check below. For each check, give the required verdict and evidence. Show your work — a bare number or claim without the underlying evidence is not acceptable output.

HARD GATES — checked first, override everything else

If either gate below FAILS, the overall verdict is NEEDS REVISION.

Do not compute or display a numeric score in that case — skip straight to the verdict and the fix list.

GATE — CHECK 7: ACCURACY & INTEGRITY

- ☐ No invented facts, statistics, names, or quotes presented as factual
- ☐ Any fact needed but not supplied is marked [PLACEHOLDER], not fabricated
- ☐ If rewriting a user's draft: original meaning and facts preserved
- ☐ Fictional/narrative detail within an intentionally fictional story (character names, invented settings) is fine and does NOT trigger this gate — this check is about claims presented as factual, not about story content

EVIDENCE: confirm every specific factual claim traces to the user's input or a source, or is marked [PLACEHOLDER]. Any unmarked invention presented as fact = FAIL, gate triggers.

GATE — CHECK 2: STRUCTURAL VARIETY (severity-graded, gates at 2+)

- Scan the full draft for ANY sentence built as three parallel clauses or items (e.g., "There was X...; Y...; and Z...", "She did A; she did B; she did C", "It was A. It was B. It was C.").
- A triad remains a triad even when each item carries its own descriptive clause, or when transition/ordinal words are inserted between items ("next," "then," "finally," "first... second... third"). Decoration and connectors do not break the pattern — judge by the underlying X; Y; and Z skeleton only.
- If the draft explicitly names or lampshades a rhetorical device it is using (e.g. "the sacred triad," "the trilogy of," "three truths") — count that as a confirmed triad regardless of how it reads.
- COUNT the confirmed triads found:
 - 0 triads → this gate PASSES, no deduction.
 - 1 triad → this gate PASSES, but flag it — apply a PARTIAL (0.5) deduction within the weighted score's Check 2 slot (see scoring below) rather than gating.
 - 2+ triads → this gate FAILS. Automatic NEEDS REVISION.

EVIDENCE: quote every triad found, in full, including decorated or connector-disguised ones. State the count explicitly. If none found, state "0 triads found" — do not skip this silently.

If both gates pass (0–1 triads, no fabrication), score the rest below.

CHECK 1 — SENTENCE-LENGTH VARIATION (burstiness) — weight 20

- ☐ No run of 3+ consecutive sentences within ~5 words of each other
- ☐ Each multi-sentence paragraph has one sentence under 8 words AND one over 25 words
- ☐ At least one very short (1–5 word) sentence somewhere in the piece

Score: 1 (all present) / 0.5 (partial — some but not all present) /

0 (largely uniform length throughout).

EVIDENCE: quote the shortest and longest sentence in the draft.

CHECK 2 SLOT — carries forward from the gate section above — weight 20

Score: 1 (0 triads) / 0.5 (exactly 1 triad, flagged) / — (2+ triads already triggered the hard gate, this section is not reached).

CHECK 3 — SPECIFICITY — weight 20

- ☐ Every paragraph carries at least one concrete, non-interchangeable detail
- ☐ No sentence could be pasted unchanged into an article on a different topic
- ☐ No empty quantifiers ("many," "various," "several") standing alone
- ☐ Specifics grounded in the user's input or NICHE & AUDIENCE PROFILE

Score: 1 (all paragraphs qualify) / 0.5 (most do, a few thin paragraphs) / 0 (mostly generic).

EVIDENCE: name one specific detail per paragraph.

CHECK 4 — HEDGING & DIRECTNESS — weight 10

- ☐ No throat-clearing openers that delay the point
- ☐ Claims stated plainly, not qualified into mush
- ☐ Tone shifts across the piece
- ☐ Some controlled imperfection present

Score: 1 / 0.5 / 0 by how many of the four are actually present.

EVIDENCE: quote one line that commits plainly; flag any hedge phrases found.

CHECK 5 — VOICE MATCH — weight 20 (excluded and rescaled if no VOICE PROFILE was supplied — see scoring note below)

- ☐ Sentence rhythm matches the VOICE PROFILE
- ☐ Transitions, vocabulary, and register match the VOICE PROFILE
- ☐ Punctuation habits match the VOICE PROFILE
- ☐ No phrase of 4+ consecutive words also appears in STYLE SOURCE, if STYLE SOURCE is visible — any match found is an automatic 0 on this check regardless of everything else, since this is a copying issue, not a style issue.

Score: 1 (matches well, no copying) / 0.5 (partial voice match) / 0

(doesn't match, or any phrase-level copying found).

EVIDENCE: name 2 specific voice traits from the profile and confirm they appear.

CHECK 6 — OVERUSED-WORD CLUSTERS — weight 10

- ☐ No cluster of flagged AI words (delve, tapestry, realm, seamless, leverage, etc.) appearing together
- ☐ Any flagged word present is the genuinely most accurate choice

Score: 1 (clean) / 0.5 (one or two isolated instances, justified) / 0

(a cluster present, or unjustified use).

EVIDENCE: list any flagged words present and justify or remove each.

CHECK 8 — ORNAMENT DENSITY (relative to VOICE PROFILE baseline) — weight 20

- ☐ Enumerate EVERY sentence in the draft, numbered, tagged PLAIN or ORNAMENTED (contains a simile, metaphor, or elevated comparison).

Show this full numbered list — a summary ratio alone is not acceptable evidence.

- ☐ Find the draft's actual ratio from that list.
- ☐ Compare against the ORNAMENT BASELINE stated in VOICE PROFILE (a fraction like "approximately 2 in 5 sentences ornamented"). If VOICE PROFILE gives no baseline, default the target to 1-in-3.

Score:

- 1 — draft's ratio is within ± 15 percentage points of the source baseline (or of 1-in-3, if no baseline given)
- 0.5 — 15–30 percentage points over the baseline
- 0 — more than 30 percentage points over the baseline

EVIDENCE: the full numbered PLAIN/ORNAMENTED list, the resulting ratio, the baseline being compared against, and which band it falls in.

SCORING

If either hard gate FAILED: stop here. State which gate failed and why. Verdict = NEEDS REVISION. Do not compute a numeric score.

If both gates passed, sum the weighted scores:

- Check 1 (weight 20) $\times$ score
- Check 2 (weight 20) $\times$ score [from the gate section: 1 or 0.5]
- Check 3 (weight 20) $\times$ score
- Check 4 (weight 10) $\times$ score
- Check 5 (weight 20) $\times$ score [omit if no VOICE PROFILE supplied]
- Check 6 (weight 10) $\times$ score
- Check 8 (weight 20) $\times$ score

If Check 5 was omitted (no VOICE PROFILE supplied): sum the remaining 6 weighted scores (out of a possible 100 total already, since weights were designed to total 100 including Check 5 — with Check 5 excluded, divide the sum by 0.8 to rescale back to a 0–100 score).

VERDICT THRESHOLDS:

85–100 READY — use as final, at most trivial polish needed

65–84 MINOR REVISION — usable, but fix the specific flagged lines before finalizing

Below 65 NEEDS REVISION — send back to the Writer Gem with the priority fix list before treating this as usable

Always show the full per-check breakdown ($\text{score} \times \text{weight} = \text{result}$) before stating the total. Re-read your own verdicts once more in the skeptical-editor mindset before finalizing — a checklist followed in letter but not intent is itself a failure of this rubric.